1962-63 Joining the Tata Group

Ratan had started working with IBM on his return from the US. He would sit in the IBM office in the Vulcan Insurance Building near Churchgate. But JRD convinced him that his rightful place was with the Tata Group. Ratan says: 'I sat and typed out my CV because IBM had nice electric typewriters which no one else had at that time. I then handed over my CV to JRD; and that's how I got into Tata.' JRD wanted Ratan to begin on the shop floors of two of the group's best-run, best-managed and largest companies, the Tata Engineering and Locomotive Company (TELCO) and the Tata Iron and Steel Company (TISCO), both situated in Jamshedpur in east India. It was a way to ensure that Ratan would start with the basics.

1991 An Unexpected Leap

Surprisingly, virtually none of the close observers of the Tata Group could make a correct assessment of who would replace JRD as the chairman of TIL. And when the decision was announced on 21 October 1981, it took many by surprise. Few expected the softspoken, introverted Ratan to be appointed JRD's successor. One leading magazine termed it an 'unexpected choice' and added that JRD, who was 'well-known as a conservative captain of industry who looks extremely carefully before he leaps ... leapt in an unexpected direction'...

A leading business daily wrote that 'Tata directors like Nani Palkhivala, Russi Mody and Minoo Mody [CEO, Tata Sons] were bitterly disappointed at Ratan's choice.' Ratan himself, with his characteristic humility, said: 'I was as pleasantly surprised—it was as if my name had been something else.'

IT WAS HER FATHER FREDERICK EMMONS WHO INTRODUCED CAROLYN TO TATA. IT WAS LOVE AT FIRST SIGHT, SHE SAYS

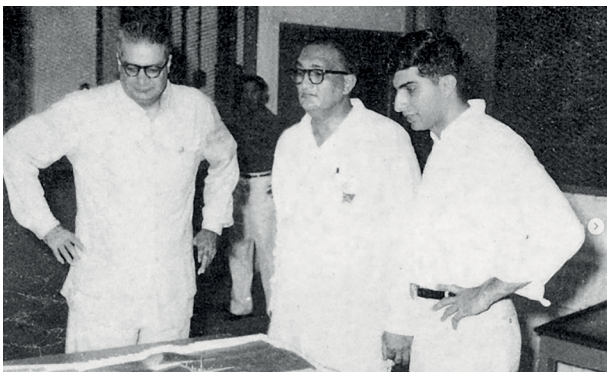
2000 The Tetley Acquisition

After taking over as chairman of the Tata Group in 1991 just two years short of its 125th year, Ratan renewed his commitment to transform the group from a primarily Indian entity to a conglomerate with a significant overseas presence. He declared it as his unwavering goal and was unremitting in his demand to the senior group leaders to accomplish this vision. He drove home this point repeatedly during the meetings of Tata company CEOs. Addressing them at the AGMM in 2000, for instance, he said: '[The] World is the market'; the 'World is the competition'; 'We cannot put our head in the sand,' we have to be 'Leaders in the changing times'. He reinforced this message in 2002 at the same forum. And this goal found its first major practical expression in Tata Tea's takeover of the British tea brand, Tetley.

2007 Targeting the Marquees: Jaguar and Land Rover

When Ratan heard from his friend Lord Kumar Bhattacharyya that Ford was looking for a suitable buyer for its luxury brands Jaguar and Land Rover, he was excited. For a self-confessed car aficionado, the temptation was irresistible. Krishna Kumar was consulted and he supported the move. Having sensed Ratan's desire to explore the possibility of buying the marquee brands, Bhattacharyya arranged a confidential trip for him to the UK in 2007. Former Tata Motors MD Ravi Kant comments that during the visit, Ratan was impressed with what he saw...







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CHILDHOOD TO CHAIRMANSHIP
Clockwise from far left, Ratan Tata with brother Jimmy in 1945; Tata on his first visit to Telco plant in Jamshedpur; Tata with Russi Mody